WEBINAR MODULE 4

Updating Value Stream Mapping & Lean for the American System

Building Productive American Capability

Joshua Konkle · Operator — configuration and execution

What You Will Leave With

- Clarity on the original intent of Value Stream Mapping and Lean
- A diagnosis of where modern practice has drifted into pure cost-out logic
- Principles for redefining value and waste around productive sovereignty
- A practical exercise you can apply to one real value stream

Classic Intent vs. Modern Drift

ORIGINAL INTENT

Make value flow.
Remove waste.
Improve the system so it serves the customer better over time.

COMMON DRIFT

Optimize primarily for lower unit labor cost and greater headcount flexibility — often through temporary labor or offshored steps.

The Productive Pragmatism Frame

Any continuous-improvement system — including Lean — must be re-oriented to these principles

01

Sovereign Productive Base

Build and control critical capabilities inside the United States

02

Merit & Capability

Develop real skill among American citizens with long-term stake

03

Directed Improvement

Capital and effort flow toward domestic capacity, not temporary labor extraction

04

People, Process, Place

High-capability American workers + advanced processes + domestic locations

Workforce Reality for Lean Practitioners

Improvements that simply reduce headcount or increase dependence on short-cycle non-sovereign labor undermine long-term capability.

Diagnostic Questions

1. Which steps in our value streams are truly critical to long-term productive capacity?

2. Do current improvement efforts increase or decrease our dependence on short-cycle non-sovereign labor?

3. Are we treating workforce stability and knowledge retention as value, or as cost to be minimized?

4. Does our definition of “waste” include loss of institutional knowledge?

Redefining Value & Waste

COUNT AS VALUE

- Building domestic productive capacity
- High-skill American roles
- Knowledge retention
- Innovation capacity
- Workforce stability

COUNT AS WASTE

- Knowledge that walks out with every temporary rotation
- Permanent design for short-cycle non-sovereign labor on critical seats
- Improvement that only banks labor-cost cuts

Practical Contrast

Traditional Cost-Out Lean asks:

“How do we do this with fewer or cheaper hours?”

Capability-Building Lean asks:

“How do we improve this value stream so it strengthens American productive capacity and creates higher-skill domestic roles?”

Innovation Example

Industrial or agricultural robotics that handle repetitive physical tasks can reduce dependence on low-skill temporary labor while creating higher-skill American employment in:

- → **Robotics engineering & systems integration**
- → **Deployment and process control**
- → **Maintenance and continuous improvement**

The value-stream design should deliberately capture that higher-skill work.

Simple Test You Can Run This Week

Pick one value stream you already know. Walk it and ask only two questions at each major step:

1. Does this step increase or decrease our dependence on short-cycle or temporary non-sovereign labor?

2. If we improved this step, would the improvement create higher-skill American work or simply remove hours?

Exercise

Select one existing value stream.
Identify two or three points where current improvement logic still optimizes for labor arbitrage or pure cost reduction.
Sketch how those points could be redesigned so the same Lean tools drive sovereign capability instead.

Directing SI in Value Streams / Lean

The human owns direction, decisions, standards, review, and final release. SI tools extend the work.

Human instruction: “Read the last 60 days of the named value stream’s process data and improvement logs from these sources I am supplying. Return a one-page note that names where knowledge is lost, where higher-skill work is created, and one step that needs an owner. Do not recommend staffing changes.”

Bot’s bounded task: Collect and draft the one-page note from the named sources only. Stop at the draft. Do not post, do not change any file, do not invent a seat recommendation.

Review criteria: (1) Every claim has a named source. (2) Open items are listed, not solved. (3) No staffing or cost-cutting recommendations are added; relevant source facts remain accurately reported. (4) The note is one page.

Human release decision: Human reads the draft against the four criteria. If all four pass, human marks it ready and releases it. If any fail, human returns it with the failed criterion named. The bot does not self-release.

Name one value stream. Write the four-part split for one use of SI in mapping its knowledge retention. Done when the four-part split is written.

Three Highest-Leverage Moves

1. Audit one major value stream for hidden dependence on short-cycle non-sovereign labor or pure cost-out logic.
2. Redefine value and waste for that stream so capability growth and domestic productive strength are explicit.
3. Align the redesigned value stream with the Business Model Canvas, OKR system, and Operating Model already covered.

Next Steps

Canvas → OKRs → Operating Model → Value Streams → Workforce Strategy

If you would like support turning these ideas into a concrete 90-day plan or ongoing configuration and execution help, reach out directly.

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